

CHORD FUNCTION & CADENCES

Every chord belongs to one of three functional groups — and those groups follow a universal narrative arc from home to tension and back.

THE THREE FUNCTIONAL CATEGORIES (KEY OF C MAJOR)

FUNCTION 1

TONIC (HOME)

Primary: **I (Cmaj7)**

I **vi** **iii**

I is primary home. vi is the relative minor — shares 2 notes with I, so it sounds like home but with a sadder tint. iii shares stable tones but is rarely used today as a tonic chord.

FUNCTION 2

SUBDOMINANT (DEPARTURE)

Primary: **IV (Fmaj7)**

IV **ii** **vii°**

IV is the classic departure — adds color and motion away from home. ii is the modern, jazzier subdominant (darker flavor). vii° is a contemporary option used in pop and neo-soul progressions.

FUNCTION 3

DOMINANT (TENSION)

Primary: **V (G7)**

V **vii°**

V7 contains the tritone — the engine of harmonic tension. Creates the strongest pull back to I. vii° is the classical dominant substitute but sounds dated in modern pop contexts. V7 is the go-to.



THE 4 CADENCE TYPES

Authentic Cadence

V → I (or V7 → I)

THE PERIOD AT THE END OF A SENTENCE

The strongest resolution in Western music. PAC (Perfect Authentic Cadence): V7 → I in root position with scale degree 1 on top. IAC (Imperfect): V → I but 3rd or 5th on top — slightly softer landing.

Plagal Cadence

IV → I

THE "AMEN" CADENCE — PEACEFUL, GENTLE

The church cadence. Softer and more peaceful than authentic — no tritone tension driving the resolution. Common in gospel, hymns, and folk. Ends on a sigh rather than a full stop.

Half Cadence

any chord → V

THE QUESTION MARK — CREATES ANTICIPATION

Ends ON the dominant — pauses on tension instead of resolving it. Like a musical question mark: "something is coming." Often used at phrase midpoints before the answer phrase resolves fully.

Deceptive Cadence

V → vi (or V → bVI)

THE PLOT TWIST — DELAYS RESOLUTION

V seems ready to resolve to I — but lands on vi instead. vi shares 2 notes with I (C-E share with Am's A-C-E), so it feels like home but with a sadder tint. Delays the full resolution beautifully. V → bVI is an even more dramatic deception.